Time Above Our Heads

Day 1 · Reading (1 of 2)

What to do: Read it aloud, one paragraph each. Stop at every blue word: can anybody explain it?

Vocabulary topic: Time, the Sun and the Moon
20 new words (in blue) · EEW 1, Unit 8 · read about calendars and time and talk about plans and meetings



easy parts harder parts (most new words are here)

What time is it? You look at your phone and you know. But for most of history, people did not have a phone, a watch or even a clock. They looked at the sky. The Sun told them when to wake up, when to eat and when to sleep. The Moon told them the month. Time was written above their heads.

Look at the **pattern** of the sky. The Sun rises and sets, and one day is finished. The Moon changes its shape from a thin line to a **huge** round light and back, and one month is finished. Ancient people noticed these patterns thousands of years ago. This was their first **theory** of time, and it was a very good one. In **contrast** with our digital watches, the sky never needs a battery, and it is never late.

Today we have a calendar with 12 months and 365 days. But a year is really 365 days and about six hours. So every four years we add one extra day, the 29th of February. A year with an extra day is called a leap year. If we do not do it, the calendar slowly moves away from the seasons.

Not every country uses the same calendar. The Islamic calendar follows the Moon, so its year is about eleven days shorter than ours, and its holidays move through the seasons. Other calendars, like the Persian one that people use for Nowruz, follow the Sun. To **arrange** a holiday, people must watch the sky carefully: the first thin crescent of the new Moon **requires** a clear night and a good pair of eyes. It is not always **necessary** to use a telescope, but you need patience.

In your book, Unit 8, you can read an old Inuit story about the Sun and the Moon. A girl and her brother run around the sky with fire, and they become the Sun and the Moon. It is a story with a **purpose**: it explains why we have day and night, and why the Moon is cold and dark.

Time Above Our Heads

Day 1 · Reading (2 of 2)

What to do: After reading: which paragraphs were easy, which were hard? Which blue words did you know already?

Time has a social side, too. When you **propose** a meeting, you must choose a time that is good for everybody. A lot of people **attend** a meeting late, and then somebody has to **accept** that the plan changed. Experts say that we have a **single** good habit to keep time: **encourage** yourself to arrive ten minutes early. And do not **grab** your phone at the first free minute. A short silent moment is a gift.

Here are some fun facts about time. A day on Earth is not exactly 24 hours: it is 23 hours, 56 minutes and a few seconds. The shortest unit of time that people can measure is much smaller than a second. And in Samarkand, Ulugh Beg's observatory was a place where people measured the length of the year with an error of less than a minute.

The best way to understand time is to find a **balance**. Do not **hang** your whole life on the clock, but do not forget it, either. Some people say they feel a **familiar** pain when the day ends and nothing has changed: they did not do anything, and there is a **tear** in their day. The cure is simple: **release** the stress, plan one small **success** every day and enjoy it.

Try a small experiment. Look at a clock for one minute, without a phone. A minute is longer than you think! Now do something for one minute: breathe, stretch or read one page. Time feels different when you pay attention.

Some cultures see time as a line, others as a circle. In a line, the past is behind you and the future is ahead, and every moment is new. In a circle, the seasons come back again and again, and people prepare for them in the same way each year. Both ideas are useful: the line teaches us to plan, and the circle teaches us to be patient.

Tonight, look at the Moon. What shape is it? Is it growing or getting smaller? Tomorrow, look again. In a week you will see a real pattern, and you will know something that people knew for thousands of years.

The 20 words

Day 1 · Vocabulary table · Topic: Time, the Sun and the Moon

What to do: Book: 4000 EEW 1, Unit 8, pages 50–53. Copy the words you do not know into the copybook.

Word	Meaning	По-русски	Example
accept v.	say yes to something offered	принимать	Please accept this small gift.
arrange v.	plan and organize something	расставлять; организовать	We arranged the chairs in a circle.
attend v.	go to an event or a place	посещать	I attend English classes three times a week.
balance n./v.	a steady position; equal parts	равновесие; удерживать	She can balance a book on her head.
contrast n.	a clear difference between two things	контраст, разница	There is a big contrast between summer and winter here.
encourage v.	give someone courage or hope to do something	поддерживать, подбадривать	My coach encourages me to try again.
familiar adj.	well known to you	знакомый	Your face looks familiar.
grab v.	take something suddenly with your hand	хватать	He grabbed his bag and ran.
hang v.	fix something so it does not touch the ground	вешать; висеть	Hang your coat on the hook.
huge adj.	very, very big	огромный	An elephant is a huge animal.
necessary adj.	needed	необходимый	Water is necessary for life.
pattern n.	a regular design or way things repeat	узор	The carpet has a beautiful pattern.
propose v.	suggest a plan or an idea	предлагать	I propose a trip to the mountains.
purpose n.	the reason for doing something	цель	What is the purpose of this machine?
release v.	let something go free	выпускать, отпускать	They released the bird into the sky.
require v.	need; make it necessary	требовать, нуждаться	This job requires a lot of patience.
single adj.	only one	один, единственный	There was not a single cloud in the sky.
success n.	doing something well; getting what you wanted	успех	The concert was a big success.
tear v.	pull apart; a drop from the eye	рвать	Be careful, don't tear the paper.
theory n.	an idea that explains something	теория	Scientists have a new theory about the stars.

More on the topic

Day 1 · Topic: Time, the Sun and the Moon · more words

What to do: Choose 5 collocations to learn. Use the reserve words when a student already knows the main ones.

Collocations: words that go together

accept an invitation	принять приглашение
arrange a meeting	организовать встречу
attend a lesson	посещать урок
keep a balance	сохранять баланс
a huge success	огромный успех
a necessary change	необходимая перемена
a pattern of…	закономерность…
in contrast to…	в отличие от…
propose an idea	предложить идею
the purpose of…	цель…
hang a picture	повесить картину
a single word	одно-единственное слово

Phrasal verbs

find out	узнать	Find out when the shop opens.
put off	отложить	We put off the meeting until Friday.
call off	отменить	They called off the trip because of rain.
sign up for	записаться на	I signed up for a course.
catch up	нагнать	Let’s catch up on the news.
hand out	раздавать	The teacher handed out the tests.

Reserve words: for students who know the 20 already, or if you prefer another word

calendar	календарь	**sunset**	закат
month	месяц	**clock**	часы (настенные)
season	время года	**schedule**	расписание
leap year	високосный год	**on time**	вовремя
sunrise	восход	**delay**	задержка

What to read next · 4000 Essential English Words

This week: **Book 1, Unit 8, “How the Sun and the Moon Were Made”**, pages 50–55. Next: **Unit 9, “The Starfish”**, pages 56–61. More about the sky: **Unit 3, “The Report”**, pages 20–25.